

Teaching Philosophy

As a teacher and student who has experienced both teacher-centered and student-centered language teaching and learning, I firmly believe that language is acquired more efficiently through social activities by using meaningful communications. In this way, creating a small community in a class and having students actively involved in it is a general guide for me when teaching English as a second language (ESL). Therefore, from my perspective, language learning takes place more naturally when students use it as a tool to convey meaning. By putting students as the primary focus in each class, I am responsible for creating such an environment for my students and facilitating their participation. The following principles may better explain what I believe effective learning and teaching are.

A safe, respectful, and positive learning environment

In my classroom, I want my students to bravely speak up if they have different ideas, and I am always sending a message that teachers are also learners and they make mistakes. In this way, I hope students treat me more like a learning partner who also wants to make progress. In another aspect, students do not worry about making mistakes in the class because they see the classroom as a learning space in which mistakes are used to check their learning progress, but not a place to perform perfectly in English proficiency. And I will provide corrective feedback in different ways according to different situations. For example, I usually do recast for students who might be aware of their mistakes, and explicit corrective feedback for mistakes which are harder to be realized. More frequently, I make elicitation to induce students' self-correction because it is a good way to avoid repeated mistakes.

Sometimes peers are the best teachers because they know what it is like to not understand. Therefore, they may have more understandable explanations. I would ask peers to help students first when they have some questions or meet learning difficulties. And I give plenty of opportunities for students to interact with each other through pair/group activities. For example, we do information-gap and opinion-gap activities in groups to complete real life tasks in order to learn different language forms, and we do peer reviews for writing. Students work cohesively and help each other out when needed. Moreover, it is worth mentioning that every student's contribution to the class is necessary and significant, and no one is left behind.

Needs analysis

Each student should know that every single part of their background is respected. And it is the teacher's responsibility to know students' backgrounds and do need analyses. Then, teaching should be designed to fulfill students' needs. In this way, teaching might be different for different groups of students because they might have different needs and goals even though they are at the same level or using the same textbook.

Task-based language teaching

Reading, listening, writing, and speaking are the four main language skills. The communicative language teaching (CLT) approach integrates all of these skills. As one of the key categories of CLT, task-based language teaching (TBLT) is what I believe brings efficiency to students' language acquisition by applying tasks related to real-life circumstances. For example, ordering pizza online, giving directions according to a map, making a travel plan, these are all tasks that students can work in class to learn English within meaningful contexts.

Therefore, completing a task becomes the primary goal rather than the linguistic production. And language is practiced through completing the task. In such a way, English learning is practical and meaningful because students get to know real-life situations by using the target language. Also, besides the traditional way of TBLT, I believe that technology-mediated TBLT can sometimes bring more significant efficiency to learning and make tasks more related to real life, for example, writing emails, playing computer games, and using Google documents are some ways I use to conduct technology-mediate TBLT. So, I am constantly training myself to get familiar with different ways we can apply technology to various tasks to best benefit students' learning.